annually from November, are these very valleys. It is in the vicinity of these places that early historic brick ruins are found. Intawa is above Bhavnath and was a Buddhist monastic site. Surajkund, marked by a late centuries BCE well and other undetermined brick remains, may well be part of a Buddhist ruin. As for Jina Baba ki Samadhi and Bhordevi, both are marked by the remnants of Buddhist stupas.

Thus, much before its fame as a centre of Jaina and Hindu worship, Girnar appears to have been sacred to the Buddhists, and possibly the earliest circuit of worship in and around the Girnar was Buddhist. It is hard to be sure of Ashoka's role in the creation of this circuit. But as the emperor's provincial capital will have been the circuit's support centre and as the emperor himself was a Buddhist, the presence of brick in the early Buddhist monuments of the Girnar forest does seem to suggest that Ashoka ploughed resources into developing places of worship and shelter for the Buddhist monastic community there.

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My account of Ashoka's imprint in the environs of Junagadh has tried to show why the idea of a standard or more or less identical message inscribed across a wide area of the empire needs to be rethought. Local interpretation mediates reception and colours understanding at every point. The fixity of inscriptions carved on rock, combined with the roughly similar ideas conveyed regardless of location, tend to make us arrive at a singular meaning, a sense of the entire edict range being reducible to a narrow range of summary statements about a contrite emperor's endeavour to create a new ethos of citizenship within an ethically governed empire. To note common threads running through the edicts should not undermine the possibility of interpretive variation and plurality of meaning. Political authority and cultural hegemony vary across regions and mediate the reception of every statement and message. Comprehension in a particular